BC-001 — Business Continuity and Disaster Recovery Helpdesk Playbook

Document control

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Approver	Chief Operating Officer
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Classification	Internal

Document type: Runbook — execute in the sequence below

1. Trigger conditions

Execute this playbook when any of the following occurs:

- Loss of a primary data center or cloud region
- Prolonged loss of a business-critical system
- Widespread network outage affecting more than one office
- Loss of a primary office location due to fire, flood, or other event
- Widespread endpoint failure affecting more than 20% of devices
- Cyber incident requiring the shutdown of production systems (see SE-004)
- Utility outage affecting more than one office
- Public health or civil event requiring office closure

2. Severity levels

Level	Definition	Activation
BC-1	Business operations severely affected across multiple offices; continuity plan activated for at least one business function	Business Continuity Manager, COO
BC-2	A business-critical system is unavailable for more than 4 hours; impact limited to one function	Business Continuity Manager
BC-3	Localized disruption with workarounds available	Service Desk Manager

3. T+0 to T+30 minutes — Initial response

T+0 — Confirm the event.

The on-duty Service Desk shift lead confirms the event by cross-checking monitoring alerts, user reports, and direct contact with the on-call engineer.

T+5 — Declare or escalate.

Shift lead declares BC-3 or escalates to the Service Desk Manager for BC-2, or to the Business Continuity Manager for BC-1. Declaration is not discretionary — if the criteria are met, declare.

T+10 — Activate the communication line.

Open a dedicated conference bridge for the incident. Notify the on-call contacts per Section 4.

T+15 — Establish current state.

Gather:

- Which systems are unavailable
- Which offices are affected
- Which business functions are affected
- Whether the event is ongoing or has stabilized

T+20 — Assess user impact.

Estimate the number of users affected and the business functions that cannot proceed.

T+30 — First communication.

Issue the first user-facing communication (see Section 6).

4. Notification matrix

Level	Notify	Time
BC-1	COO, CEO, Business Continuity Manager, affected function leaders, Legal, Communications	Within 30 min
BC-2	Business Continuity Manager, IT Director, affected function leader	Within 30 min
BC-3	Service Desk Manager, IT Operations on-call	Within 15 min

5. Immediate helpdesk actions

The Service Desk is the front line for users during a business continuity event. Immediate actions:

T+30 to T+2 hours — Stabilize communication.

- Switch the IVR message. Update the phone system greeting to inform users of the event and the alternate channel.
- Publish a status page. Public-facing status page updated with the current state and next update time.
- Staff the queue. Shift lead assigns available agents to handle incoming calls. Agents use the current status information and do not speculate.
- Consolidate tickets. Any ticket related to the event is linked to a parent incident ticket. Do not open individual tickets for users who are affected by the same event.
- Activate workarounds. Where a workaround has been established (see Section 7), communicate it clearly to affected users.

T+2 hours — Prepare for extended operation.

- Confirm agent coverage for the next 12 hours.
- Confirm the communication cadence (see Section 6).
- Confirm which systems are available via alternate access.
- If offices are inaccessible, confirm the remote work plan.

6. Communication cadence

User communication:

Phase	Cadence	Content
Initial	Once at T+30	Acknowledge, current state, next update time
Active	Every 2 hours	Current state, workarounds, next update time
Stabilized	Every 4 hours	Progress, ETA for restoration
Resolved	Once at resolution	Resolution summary, next steps if any

Internal communication:

Level	Cadence	Audience
BC-1	Every 2 hours	Executive team, function leaders
BC-2	Every 4 hours	Function leader, IT leadership
BC-3	Daily	Service Desk Manager, IT Operations

7. Common workarounds

The following workarounds are established and can be communicated to users:

Unavailable system	Workaround
Primary email	Webmail at the secondary URL; mobile app
VPN	Alternate profile ABC-CORP-Secondary (see IT-005)
Primary office	Remote work from alternate office or home
Ticketing system	Email to helpdesk mailbox; phone to Service Desk
File shares	Cloud sync for files already synced; no access to files not previously synced
ERP	Read-only access via reporting system
HRIS	HR Operations direct contact; limited self-service

Workarounds are approved by the Business Continuity Manager and communicated by the Service Desk only when approved.

8. Recovery

T+2h to T+12h — Restore services.

Restoration is managed by IT Operations, coordinated with the Business Continuity Manager. The Service Desk supports restoration by:

- Confirming user access is restored when systems come back
- Monitoring for a spike in post-restoration tickets
- Providing user guidance on post-restoration steps (e.g., re-login, data verification)

T+12h to T+48h — Verify stability.

Systems restored must be stable for 2 hours before the incident is downgraded. Stability is confirmed by:

- No alerts from monitoring
- No user reports of issues with the restored system
- IT Operations sign-off

T+48h — Resolution notice.

The Service Desk issues the final user communication and closes the parent incident ticket.

9. Post-incident review

Within 10 business days of resolution, the Business Continuity Manager convenes a post-incident review. The review covers:

- Timeline of the event
- Effectiveness of the response
- User impact
- Workarounds used and their effectiveness
- Communication effectiveness
- Action items with owners and due dates

Review findings are reported to the COO and to the next quarterly Business Continuity Steering Committee.

10. Alternate sites and remote work

If a primary office is unavailable:

- Affected users work remotely if systems are available
- Alternate offices are activated per the office occupancy plan
- Travel to alternate offices is coordinated with Facilities

The office occupancy plan is maintained by Facilities and reviewed quarterly.

11. Testing

This playbook is tested annually through a tabletop exercise. The exercise includes the Service Desk, IT Operations, and at least one business function. Exercise findings are documented and playbook updates are made within 30 days.

12. Related documents

- SD-001 Ticket Intake, Triage, and Priority Matrix
- SD-002 Escalation, Handoff, and Major Incident Communication
- SE-004 Incident Reporting and Security Escalation
- FI-004 Travel Booking, Authorization, and Duty of Care
- IT-005 VPN and Remote Access Quick Reference

13. Revision history

Version	Date	Change
1.5	09/20/2023	Notification matrix revised
1.8	03-14-2024	Workarounds table added
2.0	March 14, 2025	Testing section added; remote work guidance clarified